



TURF WAR

National Technical Research Organisation (NTRO): Set up in 2004 as a hub supplying all other security agencies and armed forces with technical intelligence.

Aviation Research Centre (ARC): Technical intelligence division of RAW, set up with CIA assistance in 1963. Unwilling to cede control to NTRO.

Key government decisions on NTRO have not been implemented:

Technical assets: It has spy satellites but no spy planes. Acquisition plan stalled by ARC.

Intelligence database: RAW and IB have refused to feed inputs.

Cyber warfare: No sanction for computer hacking and monitoring.

Intelligence analysis: It can collect but not analyse technical intelligence data.

and electronic intelligence. The ARC fed its intelligence inputs only to RAW under which it operated, hence the review committee recommended a nodal agency which would supply multiple users—from the armed forces to state governments battling Naxalites—with TECHINT. However, the NTRO project for setting up of a repository of intelligence where users could plug in for inputs came to naught when both the Intelligence Bureau (IB) and RAW refused to provide any data. "We have the money, resources and technology but we don't have the vision and the will to create an effective intelligence sharing mechanism," rues an NTRO official.

Like RAW, the organisation forms part of the Cabinet Secretariat and reports directly to National Security Adviser M.K. Narayanan. The chairman—also called secretary, NTRO—holds the same rank as the RAW chief. Yet, till date the organisation is yet to get its own building and functions from three locations scattered over the national Capital. In the early days, intelligence provided by NTRO was disregarded by the National Security Council (NSC) and its members were not

even allowed to sit in on meetings of the Joint Intelligence Committee, a forum of all top intelligence agencies. NTRO, which has a staff strength of around 800, is already grappling with an exodus of sorts. At least six senior officials have left in the past one year and the critical post of cyber applications and research is yet to be filled. Its emaciated, powerless state has prompted calls for its closure. "The NTRO experiment has been a failure, the Government should wind it up and instead build up ARC with more assets and give it more autonomy," says Air Marshal (retired) Ashok K. Goel, ARC's former head of operations.

The organisation headed by a DRDO scientist K.V.S.S. Prasad Rao, has attracted criticism from other intelligence agencies, which say it is too technical—staffed with scientists instead of experienced intelligence operatives. "Intelligence cannot be generated in a vacuum. Unless you have specialists in various areas you will not know where and how to task your technical resources like satellites and UAVs," says former RAW official R.S.N. Singh. NTRO officials say they are,

in fact, barred from carrying out actual field work because the intelligence establishment is not adequately sensitised about the importance of new technologies and cyber warfare.

In the US, NSA designs cipher systems to protect information systems and search for weaknesses in adversaries' systems and codes. It coordinates and performs highly specialised activities to protect US information systems and provides foreign intelligence information. It is a high technology organisation at the frontiers of communication and data processing. All the Communications Intelligence (COMINT) and Signals Intelligence (SIGINT) efforts of the US are grouped under NSA. "In contrast, NTRO in India does not have exclusive control as several other agencies like RAW and IB continue to maintain their COMINT and SIGINT assets. This is another instance of duplication of scarce resources and wasteful expenditure," says Major-General (retired) Vinay Kumar Singh, former RAW official and author of the controversial new book on the agency, *India's External Intelligence*.

More than the practical experience or the inability of the Government to simply merge ARC and NTRO, it seems to be the lack of a godfather that is hobbling the organisation. RAW had the formidable Rameshwar Nath Kao who carved the external intelligence organisation out of IB in 1968. NTRO briefly had one in the person of former national security adviser J.N. Dixit, but was orphaned by his sudden demise six months after he took over in 2004. "Dixit perfectly understood the importance of such an organisation and I'm convinced that had he been alive today, the whole set-up would have been different," says former NTRO chairman R.S. Bedi. As a member of KAC's technical task force on intelligence, Narayanan was one of the most enthusiastic proponents of the idea for a technical intelligence organisation. Today, he seems either unwilling to or unable to get the agency off the ground. (Narayanan did not respond to a questionnaire sent by INDIA TODAY).

It took a Kargil War to set up NTRO. What would it take to give it more power is the uncomfortable question no one seems to be asking just yet. ■